

Jeremiah Gutierrez

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SUMMARY

President and operator with 20+ years of experience building teams, scaling companies, and developing leaders. 14-year YPO member and spouse forum participant who has seeded and facilitated peer forums from the ground up. Proven track record in executive leadership, group facilitation, organizational development, and driving results in high-stakes environments. Currently pursuing YPO Certified Forum Facilitator (CFF) designation.

EXPERIENCE

President — *United National Consumer Suppliers (UNCS)* Jan 2019 – Present

- Lead all operations for a national wholesale distribution company that sources products globally and places them across retail and e-commerce channels
- Oversee strategic planning, vendor partnerships, supply chain optimization, and team development across the organization
- Built and sustained long-term vendor and client relationships through a "life-long-transaction" philosophy
- Seeded a Forum for Business program inside UNCS using the YPO International framework, bringing structured peer group facilitation to the leadership team

Human Resources Director — *UNCS* Oct 2008 – Jan 2019

- Designed and implemented HR infrastructure including hiring, onboarding, training, performance management, and compliance
- Developed employee training programs focused on communication, accountability, and team dynamics
- Partnered with executive leadership on organizational development, culture building, and succession planning

Food Service Director — *ARAMARK Corporation* Jun 2006 – Mar 2008

- Managed food service operations for a Fortune 500 contract services provider
- Oversaw staff, budgets, and client satisfaction across multi-site operations

Private Corporate Chef — *Starmark International* Jan 2005 – Jun 2006

- Provided executive dining and event catering for a national advertising and brand strategy agency

Vice President — *Health Nuts Cafe* Feb 2002 – Jan 2005

- Co-led operations for a fresh food concept focused on health-conscious, grab-and-go dining
- Managed vendor sourcing, menu development, staffing, and daily operations

Vice President & Project Manager — *LakeRidge Development Group* Jan 2000 – Jan 2002

- Oversaw real estate development projects from planning through execution
- Managed budgets, timelines, contractors, and regulatory compliance

General Manager — *Lake Ridge Rentals, Inc.* Jan 1998 – Jan 2002

- Managed full operations of a property rental company including leasing, maintenance, and tenant relations

LEADERSHIP & BOARD SERVICE

Chair of the Board — Broward Partnership for the Homeless, Inc. (BPHI)

Lead board governance, strategic direction, and stakeholder engagement for one of Broward County's largest homeless services organizations. Work alongside community leaders, executives, and philanthropists on housing and social impact initiatives.

Spouse Forum Officer — YPO Miami

Seeded and facilitated the chapter's first professional spouse forum from the ground up. Recruited members, established group norms, led structured exercises, built psychological safety, and developed the group's first moderator.

CERTIFICATIONS & AFFILIATIONS

- ♦ **YPO Certified Forum Facilitator (CFF)** — Candidate, 2026
- ♦ **YPO Member & Spouse Forum Participant** — 14 years combined
- ♦ **Founder, Exercise Roulette** — AI-powered fitness platform (exerciseroulette.com)
- ♦ **Founder, Agent 97 Holdings** — Holding company for technology and services ventures

EDUCATION

- ♦ **Kaplan University** — Business Administration, Human Resources
- ♦ **Florida Culinary Institute** — Culinary Arts

CORE COMPETENCIES

Executive Leadership | Group Facilitation | Organizational Development | Team Building & Training | Strategic Planning | Peer Forum Design | Psychological Safety | Employee Development | Vendor & Client Relations | Supply Chain Management | Board Governance | Executive Coaching | Change Management | Stakeholder Engagement

"The Weight You Carried In"

Build or Repair Relationships Within a Group

Jeremiah Gutierrez — YPO CFF Application 2026

OBJECTIVE

To rebuild connection and trust in a Forum group that has become surface-level, transactional, or disconnected — often after a conflict, a membership change, or a period where members have been "showing up but not really showing up."

This exercise creates a structured, low-risk entry point for vulnerability by asking members to name something they're currently carrying that the group doesn't know about. It works because it bypasses the instinct to perform and invites honesty without requiring a full presentation or life-walk level of exposure.

When to use it:

- A group has gone flat — sessions feel routine, updates replace real sharing
- After a conflict or trust rupture that was addressed but not fully resolved
- When new members have joined and the group hasn't re-established its depth
- At the start of a retreat to set the tone for the sessions ahead

INSTRUCTIONS

Setup (5 minutes)

The facilitator frames the exercise:

"We're going to do something simple but not easy. Every person in this room is carrying something right now — a decision, a fear, a question, a weight — that the rest of us don't know about. Not because you're hiding it, but because we haven't created the space for it. That's what we're going to do right now."

Ground rules (restate even if the group knows them):

- Confidentiality applies fully
- No advice, no fixing, no problem-solving
- Listening is the response
- You share what you're ready to share — there is no minimum or maximum

Round 1: Writing (5 minutes, silent)

Each member writes on a card or piece of paper, completing this sentence:

"Something I'm carrying right now that this group doesn't know about is..."

One sentence. No explanation needed yet. The act of writing it down is the first step.

Round 2: Sharing (3–5 minutes per person)

Go around the room. Each person reads their sentence aloud, then — only if they choose — expands on it briefly. The facilitator's role:

- Hold the silence after each share. Do not rush to the next person.
- If someone's share lands heavily, acknowledge it: "Thank you. That took courage."
- If someone passes, honor it without commentary.

Round 3: Reflection (10 minutes, open)

The facilitator opens a group reflection:

"What shifted in the room just now? What did you notice — in yourself or in the group?"

This is where the repair happens. Members will often name that they didn't realize others were carrying similar things, or that they'd been holding back without knowing why. The facilitator's job is to let the group make meaning of what just happened — not to interpret it for them.

Close (2 minutes)

The facilitator closes with a forward-facing question:

"What does this group need from each other going forward to keep this kind of honesty alive?"

Let 2–3 members respond. Do not force a conclusion. The question plants the seed.

SAFETY

Emotional risk: This exercise asks for vulnerability. The facilitator must read the room before launching it. If a group is actively in conflict or a member is in acute crisis, this exercise may not be appropriate — address the immediate issue first.

Passing is always an option. State this explicitly at the start. No one should feel pressured to share more than they're ready for.

No cross-talk during Round 2. The instinct to comfort, relate, or advise is strong. The facilitator must hold the boundary: listening is the response.

Facilitator self-regulation: If a member's share triggers a personal reaction in you, notice it and set it aside. Your job is to hold space, not to process your own response in real time.

Follow-up: If a member shares something that suggests they need support beyond what Forum provides (mental health crisis, safety concern), the facilitator should check in privately after the session and help connect them with appropriate resources. Forum is not therapy.

EXAMPLE

Context:

A spouse forum I facilitated had been meeting for several months but had settled into a pattern of surface-level updates — business wins, kids' milestones, travel plans. The sessions were pleasant but not powerful. Two members had a disagreement outside of Forum that they hadn't addressed in the group, and the unspoken tension was pulling everyone toward safe territory.

What happened:

I opened the session with this exercise instead of the planned agenda. During the writing phase, the room went quiet in a way it hadn't before — the kind of silence where people are actually thinking, not just waiting. When we moved to sharing, one member read her sentence and then paused. She said, "I didn't realize how heavy that was until I said it out loud." Another member shared something about a family situation that he'd been carrying for months. The two members who'd had the disagreement didn't address it directly during the exercise — but during the reflection round, one of them said, "I think I've been holding back because I wasn't sure this was a safe place to be messy." That opened the door.

Result:

The exercise didn't "fix" the group in one session — that's not how trust works. But it created a reset. The following sessions had noticeably more depth. Members started self-correcting when conversations drifted to surface level: "Are we doing updates, or are we doing Forum?" That question became the group's own accountability mechanism.

Facilitator learning:

The most important thing I did was hold the silence. My instinct was to fill the gaps, to affirm, to move things along. Instead, I waited. The group filled the silence with honesty — which is always better than anything I could have said.

"Below the Waterline"

A Two-Day Forum Retreat for Re-Deepening

Jeremiah Gutierrez — YPO CFF Application 2026

OBJECTIVE

A retreat designed for an established Forum group (2+ years together) that has built trust but plateaued in depth. The group knows each other well enough to be comfortable — and that comfort has become the ceiling.

The retreat is structured to take the group below their current waterline: past the stories they've already told, into the questions they haven't asked themselves yet. It uses a progression from reflection to vulnerability to forward commitment, with each session building on the one before.

This retreat is appropriate when:

- A Forum group has been together for 2+ years and sessions feel predictable
- Members report that Forum is "good" but not transformative
- The group wants to go deeper but doesn't know how to get there
- A facilitator has been brought in to help the group break through a ceiling

This retreat is NOT appropriate when:

- The group has active, unresolved conflict (address that first)
- A member is in acute personal crisis (provide individual support first)
- The group has fewer than 6 months together (trust foundation isn't ready)

INSTRUCTIONS

Pre-Retreat (2 weeks before)

Facilitator sends each member a private prompt:

"Think about a question you've been avoiding — about your business, your relationships, your life, or yourself. You don't have to share it yet. Just know what it is. Bring it with you."

This seeds the retreat's theme without prescribing content. Members arrive already in a reflective state. Facilitator also requests a current Forum health check (anonymous, 5 questions: safety, depth, relevance, honesty, commitment) and any topics members want the retreat to address.

Day 1: "What We Show vs. What We Carry"

Session 1: Arrival & Grounding (90 minutes)

TIME	ACTIVITY	PURPOSE
0:00	Welcome, ground rules restatement, confidentiality reaffirmation	<i>Reset the container — even experienced Forums need this at a retreat</i>
0:10	Check-in round: "What's one word for where you are right now — and one word for where you want to be by the end of this retreat?"	<i>Low-barrier entry point; creates a benchmark to revisit at close</i>
0:30	Facilitator shares Forum health check themes (anonymized, no attribution)	<i>Holds up a mirror — lets the group see its own patterns</i>
0:45	Open discussion: "What did you notice? What surprised you?"	<i>Group makes meaning of its own data</i>
1:15	Break	

Session 2: The Iceberg Exercise (2 hours)

TIME	ACTIVITY	PURPOSE
0:00	Facilitator introduces the iceberg metaphor: above the waterline is what the group already knows about you; below is what you haven't shared — not because you're hiding, but because you haven't been asked or haven't been ready	<i>Frames vulnerability as expansion, not exposure</i>
0:15	Individual writing (silent, 15 min): Each member draws their own iceberg — above the line: what this Forum knows about me. Below the line: what they don't.	<i>The visual makes abstract concepts concrete</i>
0:30	Paired sharing (30 min): Members pair up and share their icebergs. Each person gets 15 minutes. Partner's only role: listen and ask one clarifying question. No advice.	<i>Pairs are safer than the full group; builds momentum for the larger share</i>
1:00	Full group round (60 min): Each member shares one thing from below their waterline that they want the group to know. Facilitator holds space — no cross-talk until everyone has shared.	<i>This is the core of the retreat. The facilitator's job is to protect this space.</i>
2:00	Break	

Session 3: Evening Dinner — No Agenda

Unstructured time together. No facilitation, no exercises. The conversations that happen organically after a deep session are often where the real bonding occurs. The facilitator is present but not "on."

Day 2: "What Comes Next"

Session 4: The Question You've Been Avoiding (2 hours)

TIME	ACTIVITY	PURPOSE
0:00	Facilitator reconnects to the pre-retreat prompt: "You were asked to come with a question you've been avoiding. Today is when we work on it."	<i>Brings the thread forward; members have had a full day to build courage</i>
0:10	Presentation format (modified): Each member gets 10–12 minutes. State the question. Share why you've been avoiding it. Share what you think the answer might be — and what scares you about that answer.	<i>This format prevents advice-giving by design. The member does their own work in front of the group.</i>
0:10–1:40	Group presentations (8 members × ~12 min, adjust for group size)	<i>Facilitator manages time, holds boundaries, ensures each member gets equal space</i>
1:40	Group reflection: "What patterns did you hear across our questions?"	<i>Often the group discovers shared themes — isolation, identity, transition — that normalize individual struggles</i>
2:00	Break	

Session 5: Commitments & Close (90 minutes)

TIME	ACTIVITY	PURPOSE
0:00	Individual writing (10 min): "Based on this retreat, what is one commitment you're making to yourself? And one commitment you're making to this Forum?"	<i>Two commitments — personal and group — creates accountability on both levels</i>

TIME	ACTIVITY	PURPOSE
0:10	Sharing round (40 min): Each member reads both commitments aloud. Group witnesses — no discussion, no feedback.	<i>Public commitment increases follow-through; witnessing creates shared accountability</i>
0:50	Facilitator revisits the opening check-in: "You gave us two words at the start — where you were and where you wanted to be. Where are you now?"	<i>Bookends the retreat; members can feel the distance traveled</i>
1:10	Facilitator close: Thank the group. Name what you observed (without interpreting). Remind them that the retreat isn't the work — the work is what happens in the next 6 months of sessions.	<i>Grounds the experience in ongoing Forum life, not just the retreat high</i>
1:30	End	

SAFETY

Pre-retreat screening: The facilitator should have a private conversation with the Forum moderator before the retreat to understand group dynamics, any unresolved tensions, and whether any member is in a vulnerable state that requires extra care.

Opt-out is always available. At every stage, members can choose the depth of their participation. The facilitator states this at the start and reinforces it before the Iceberg Exercise and the Avoided Question session.

Confidentiality is restated, not assumed. Even groups that have been together for years need to hear it again at a retreat, especially before deeper exercises.

Emotional escalation protocol: If a member's share moves into territory that feels like it needs professional support (disclosure of abuse, active suicidal ideation, addiction crisis), the facilitator pauses the exercise, checks in with the member privately, and helps connect them with appropriate resources. Forum is not therapy — the facilitator must know the boundary and hold it.

Facilitator self-care: A two-day retreat is emotionally demanding for the facilitator. Build in personal debrief time after each day. Do not process the group's content with anyone outside the group.

Post-retreat follow-up: The facilitator checks in with the moderator 2–4 weeks after the retreat to assess whether the depth is carrying forward into regular sessions. If it isn't, that's valuable information for the next intervention.

EXAMPLE

Context:

I designed the core elements of this retreat based on my experience facilitating the YPO Miami spouse forum and the Forum for Business program I seeded in my organization. The Iceberg Exercise emerged from a session where I noticed that members had told their "greatest hits" stories but hadn't gone beneath them — the group knew what everyone had accomplished but not what they were afraid of.

What happened with the Iceberg Exercise:

When I first used a version of this in my spouse forum, the paired sharing phase was the turning point. One pair spent their entire 30 minutes on a single question one partner asked: "What's the thing below the line that you think would change how we see you?" When they came back to the full group, the energy had shifted. People shared things they'd held for months — not because they were prompted with the "right" question, but because someone else's willingness gave them permission.

What happened with the Avoided Question format:

In the Forum for Business sessions, I adapted the presentation format to focus on questions rather than updates or problems. The shift from "Here's my situation, help me solve it" to "Here's a question I've been avoiding, and here's why" changed the quality of the conversation entirely. Members stopped performing competence and started exploring uncertainty. One leader shared that the question he'd been avoiding was whether he was in the right role — a conversation he couldn't have in any other room.

Facilitator learning:

The most important design choice in this retreat is the progression. Day 1 builds the safety and depth. Day 2 uses it. If you reverse the order — if you ask people to share their avoided questions before they've done the iceberg work — you get polished, safe answers. The depth comes from the sequence, not from any single exercise.